Case Study: Rhino Foods

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Overview

What Matters

- Inclusive hiring & workforce development
- Balancing people and profit

What Works

- Building supportive work environments
- Investing in people

What Lasts

- Building an inclusive company with workers from various lived experiences

SWOT Analysis

Strengths

Strong community and brand ties

Up-to-date technology & systems

Established immigration hiring program

Comprehensive employee welfare programs

Weaknesses

Declining enrollment in the immigrant hiring program

Retention struggles in prison hiring program

Employee transportation barriers

Opportunities

Deepening community partnership

Revenue and brand recognition growth

Expanding corporate social responsibility efforts

Becoming a premier food brand for social impact

Threats

Financial strain from program maintenance

Competition from more efficient rivals

Workforce shortages from hiring challenges

Lingering supply chain disruptions

PESTLE Analysis

P — Political

Biden Admin prioritizes ESG & CSR

PPP supports business recovery

E — Economic

Growing demand for ethical businesses

Government stimulus aid economic recovery

S — Social

Employees seek purpose-driven jobs

Increased awareness of social and racial inequality

T — Technological

Improved ESG data tracking & statistics

Growth in sustainable technology adoption

L — Legal

Labor laws enhance worker protections

Stronger ESG compliance and reporting requirements

E — Environmental

Corporate push for net-zero emissions

Climate change disrupts supply chains

rhino FOODS

Challenge Statement

Rhino Foods must balance **inclusive hiring, employee retention, and operational efficiency** to ensure new hires thrive while meeting production demands. As labor shortages and supply chain disruptions persist, the company needs **sustainable workforce solutions** that align with its **people-first mission and long-term business success**.

Potential Solutions

Stay on Course

Retain *No Background Checks* and continue current recruitment and onboarding strategy

Strengthen existing *New Americans* program due to rising global tensions

Leverage the success of *New Americans*, which has been proven

Does not address current employee's concerns over criminal history

Potential Solutions

New Vermonters

Phase out the *No Background Checks* program

Adopt *New Vermonters*, a scaled-up *New Americans*, now including U.S. residents and citizens new to the state of Vermont

Seize opportunity in growing domestic migrant population in Vermont

Deviates from core company principle of pioneering innovative hiring practices

Potential Solutions

Halfway House Partnership

Revise *No Background Checks*

Partner with halfway houses, providing employment to inmates participating in reentry and reintegration programs

Addresses low retention rate, as employment is mandatory and there are existing supports

High early-stage turnover

Legal & compliance complexity

Potential Solutions

Enhanced NBC

Retain and implement an enhanced application of *No Background Checks*

Create more supports for employees to improve recruitment and retention

Aligns with company vision of inclusive hiring practices

Increases employee support, which could address employee retention issues

Ability to continue a meaningful program central to company ethos

Decision Matrix

	Criteria	Weighting	1. Stay on Course	2: New Vermonters	3: Halfway House Partnership	4: Enhanced NBC
Suitability (addresses issues)	Aligns with Rhino's mission?	10%	8	5	9	10
	Balances inclusivity & operations?	10%	7	5	8	10
	Fits long-term strategy?	10%	6	5	6	9
Acceptability (acceptable to stakeholders)	Leadership support?	15%	7	5	6	8
	Employee support?	15%	6	4	6	9
	Public perception?	10%	8	7	7	9
Feasibility (can it be implemented successfully)	Resources available?	10%	8	8	5	8
	Ability to implement?	10%	8	7	5	9
	Long-term sustainability?	10%	7	5	6	9
		100%	**72%**	**56%**	**64%**	**90%**

Our Proposal

R

Recruitment

New programs to increase recruitment

Operational changes to ensure efficiency

O

Operations

S

Supports

New support framework to empower employees

ROSI's impact on Rhino Foods

I

Impact

Recruitment

Record Flags
Implement new system

Automated system
Flags on predetermined criteria
P&C blind to unflagged records

CTE Programs
Lobby institutions

Lobby facilities to add CTE programs
Perkins law & DOJ provide funds
Prepares inmates for re-entry

Operations

Crash Course

Refine programming

Expand to four days

Apply MTSS principles to refine

Part Time On-Ramp

For new hires

Employees gradually re-enter workforce

Flexible scheduling & hours

Reduces stress on new employees

Support Systems

Universal Screening

All employees continuously assessed for supports

Equity & Inclusion

Tiered system acknowledges differing needs

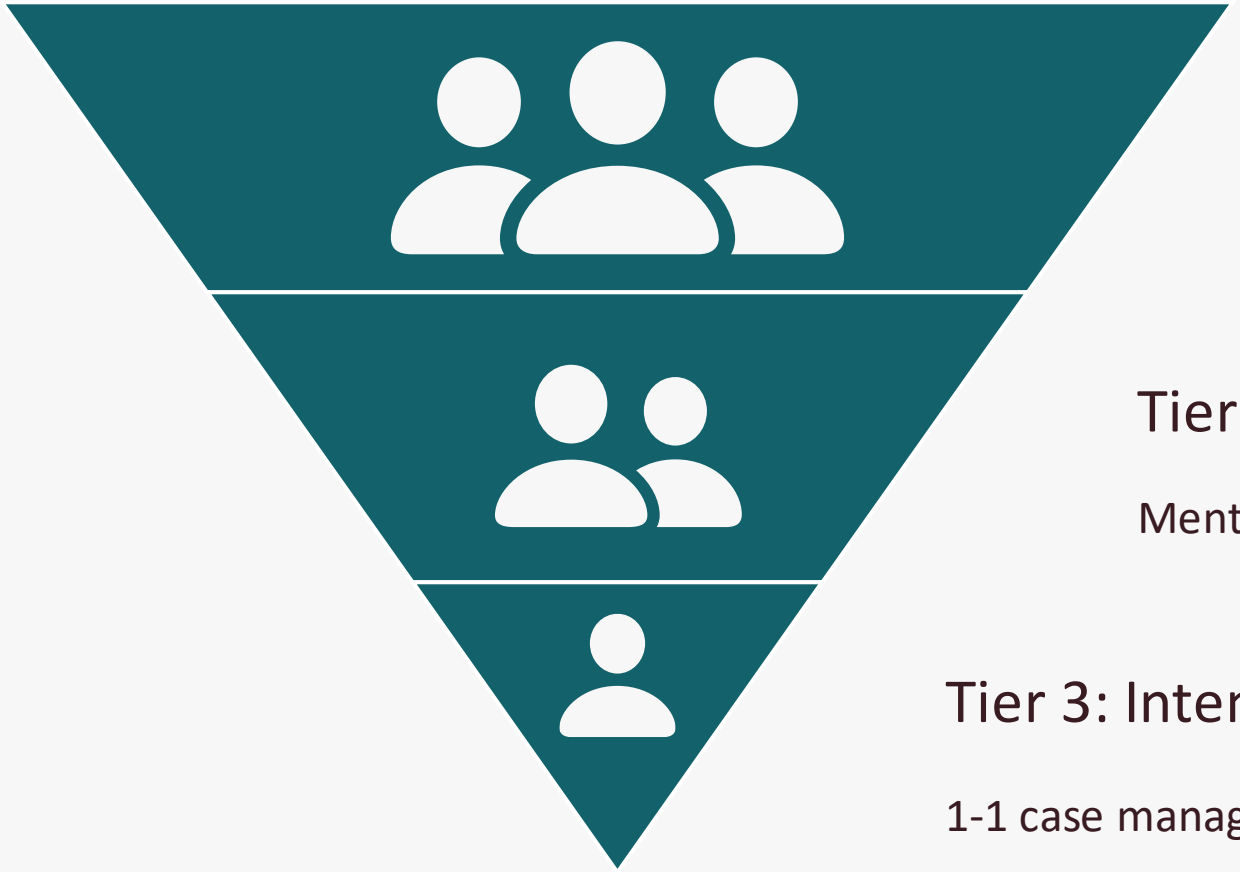
Data-Driven Decision Making

Ensures employees are receiving necessary supports

Early Intervention

Proactively identify and address barriers

MTSS Framework



Tier 1: Universal Supports

Trainings, clear policies, Rhino Week!

Tier 2: Targeted Supports

Mentor programs, part time on-ramp

Tier 3: Intensive Supports

1-1 case management, crisis intervention, IAP

Why It Works

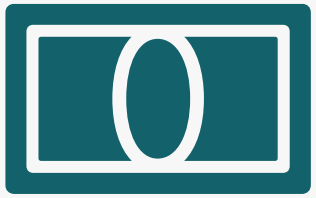
MTSS Framework

- Universal screening
- Data-based decisions
- Early intervention
- Adaptable and scalable
- Centralized support mgmt.
- Continuous improvement

Support Programs

Onsite Daycare
Tier 2 support
New!

Full day & part time care
Free of charge



Income Advance Program
Tier 3 support
Updated!

Increase loan
maximum to $1500

Impact

Support Systems

MTSS streamlines employee supports Daycare & IAP enhancements add employee resources

Recruitment

New programs enhance career readiness while ensuring safety via record flagging

Operations

Updated crash course and part time on-ramp program support New Rhinos transition back into the workplace

Risk Assessment

Impact	Rare	Unlikely	Moderate	Likely	Almost Certain
Severe			R4		R1
Major		R3	R5		
Moderate		R7	R6	R2	
Minor					
Negligible					

Likelihood

Risks

R1 Implementation Complexity

R2 Employee Adaptation Period

R3 Operational Adjustments

R4 Scalability Challenges

R5 Resource Requirements

R6 Culture Fit and Workplace Dynamics

R7 Regulatory Compliance

Implementation Timeline

Time from now (quarters)

Program	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q5	Q6	Q7	Q8
Implement MTSS	X	X	X					
Daycare contract				X	X	X		
Enhance Crash Course	X	X						
Part Time On-Ramp		X	X					
IAP increase	X	X	X	X	X			
Lobby for CTE		X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Implement Daycare						X	X	X

+2 years

Department Key
People & Culture
Technical Services
Senior Leadership
Contractor

Plan B: Stay on Course

SAF Score

72%

ROSI's Most Severe Risks

- Scaling
- Implementation

Rising global tensions may displace tens of thousands. This could increase New Americans in Vermont.

If ROSI implementation is not successful:

- Retain No Background Checks and continue New Americans
- Scale back to pre-ROSI hiring and retention scheme
- Keep existing employee supports

ROSI

By Trailblaze Talent Solutions

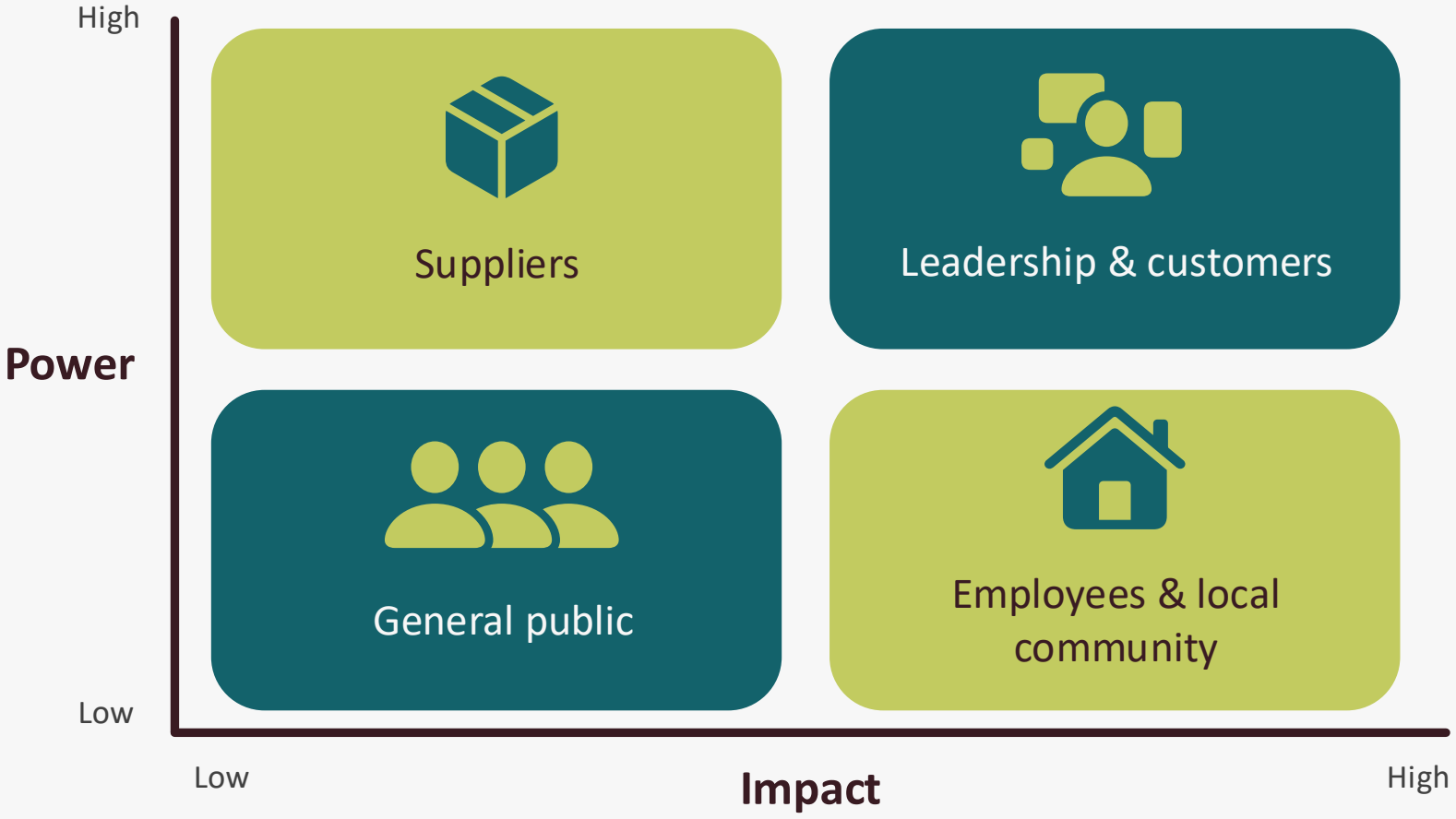
Appendix

1. Performance & Impact Assessment Framework
2. Stakeholder Analysis
3. Porter's Five Forces
4. Restructured Crash Course
5. Financial Impact of ROSI Solution
6. Financial Impact Calculations of ROSI
7. Financial Justification: Industry Benchmarks
8. Risk Mitigation
9. Additional Alternative Solution

1. Performance & impact assessment Framework

Assessment Area	Key Metrics	Review Period
Employee Retention	Turnover rate reduction, average tenure increase	Quarterly
Operational Efficiency	Shift optimization, reduce downtime	Quarterly
Hiring & Inclusivity	Diversity of hires, % of non-traditional employees retained	Bi-Annual
Workforce Productivity	Productivity per worker, quality control metrics	Quarterly
Stakeholder Satisfaction	Employee & leadership satisfaction surveys, external reputation	Annual
Long-Term Sustainability	Scalability of program, alignment with long-term goals	Bi-Annual

2. Stakeholder Analysis



3. Porter’s Five Forces

New Entry

- High startup costs and supply chain issues
- Strict regulations limit new competitors.

Buyers

- Demand for ethical, high-quality products
- Price sensitivity post-pandemic.

Substitutes

- Growth in plant-based and sustainable foods
- Innovation in alternative food options.

Suppliers

- COVID-19 disruptions increase supplier control
- Rising costs for raw materials and sustainability

Competitive Rivalry

- High competition, especially in ethical brands
- Strong brand loyalty and price wars

4. Restructured Crash Course

Day	Focus Area	Key Topics
Day 1	Welcome to Rhino Foods	- Company history, values, and culture - Introduction to the "Do Right" ethos - Employee expectations & workplace policies
Day 2	Job-Specific Training & Hands-On Learning	- Role responsibilities & daily workflow - Equipment, tools, and safety protocols - Shadowing experienced employees
Day 3	Workplace Efficiency & Career Growth	- Shift scheduling & teamwork best practices - Career advancement opportunities & upskilling - Employee support systems & mentorship
Day 4	Final Integration & Continuous Learning	- Workplace problem-solving scenarios - Q&A with leadership & employee resource groups - Final assessments & long-term success strategies

5. Financial Impact of ROSI

Metric	Current Cost Estimate	Projections	Justification
Turnover Cost Savings	$150,000 - $500,000	$75,0000 - $250,000	Reduced hiring, training, and onboarding costs
Overtime Cost Reduction	$577,300	$288,650	Optimized scheduling, better workforce planning
Hiring & Training Cost Savings	$400,000	$200,000	Lower onboarding costs, improved retention
Productivity Gains	N/A	$200,000+	More efficient workforce, fewer disruptions
Total Estimated Savings	~ $1.1M+ annually	~ $750,000+ annually	Hybrid strategy optimizes costs & efficiency

6. Financial Impact Calculations of ROSI

Metric	Calculation	Industry Benchmark & Justification
Turnover Cost Savings	100 employees × $1,500 (replacement cost) = $150,000 per year 50% reduction → $75,000 saved annually	The average cost to replace an hourly worker is $1,500 (BuiltIn, 2023).
Overtime Cost Reduction	100 employees × 3.6 overtime hours/week × $30.84/hr × 52 weeks = $577,300 per year 50% reduction → $288,650 saved annually	Manufacturing workers average 3.6 overtime hours per week (BLS, 2023).
Hiring & Training Cost Savings	50 employees retained × $8,000 (replacement cost) = $400,000 per year 50% reduction → $200,000 saved annually	Replacing an employee costs 16-20% of annual salary (SHRM, 2023).
Productivity Gains	200 employees × $100,000 revenue per employee × 17% productivity increase = $3.4M total impact	Engaged employees are 17% more productive (Gallup, 2023).
Total Estimated Savings	$75,000 + $288,650 + $200,000 = ~$750,000 annually	Hybrid strategy improves retention, efficiency, and cost management.

7. Financial Justification: Industry Benchmarks

- Bureau of Labor Statistics. (2023). *The employment situation – Table B-23: Average weekly hours and overtime of production and nonsupervisory employees on private nonfarm payrolls by industry sector, seasonally adjusted*. U.S. Department of Labor.
- Built In. (2023). *Cost of employee turnover: How much does losing an employee really cost?*
- Gallup. (2023). *The right culture: Not employee satisfaction, but employee engagement*.
- GNA Partners. (2023). *How much does employee turnover really cost your business?*
- KMCO. (2023). *The true costs of high employee turnover*.
- SHRM (Society for Human Resource Management). (2023). *The cost of replacing an employee*.

8. Risk Mitigation

Identified Risks	Mitigation Strategy
Implementation Complexity	Phased implementation, as outlined in implementation timeline, to reduce risk of overwhelming the concerned departments
Employee Adaptation Period	Extended and restructured crash course to ease in new employees; Mentorship program to build rapport
Operational Adjustments	Part time on-ramp to ease in new employees and reduce operational disruptions from lowered retention rate
Scalability Challenges	Data-based decision-making: regularly review program effectiveness and adjust support structures as needed
Resource Requirements	Continuously monitor and assess the financial return of the program and adjust budget allocations as needed
Culture Fit and Workplace Dynamics	Establish clear behavioral guidelines; highlight success stories of No Background Checks to foster empathy
Regulatory Compliance	Maintain clear and detailed documentation of all hiring practices and support services; regularly audit hiring and operational practices to stay compliant with changing regulations

9. Potential Solutions

Inmate Workforce Program

Employ incarcerated individuals to fill weekend shifts

Offer maximum rate, higher than the average for incarcerated employees

Provides employment opportunity for currently incarcerated individuals, as well as pathway into the workforce post-sentence

Negative perception on adopting this strategy